

P P.V. Sindhu, a double Olympic medallist, regained her confidence and form after a standout performance at the Badminton Asia Team Championships in Malaysia, where Indian women beat favourite Thailand 3-2 in a thrilling final to win their first-ever gold in the tournament.

"It was just a question of getting the act right. Having played for so long at the highest level and won so many medals, I knew in my heart that all it takes to be back where you should be is to play quality games," Sindhu said.

"That's what happened. I enjoyed the whole championship and the challenge of giving a winning start. Stay focussed and confident is the mantra for me right now in the year of the Paris Olympics," the champion shuttler added.

Sindhu, the world No. 11, kicked off the Indian title charge in style, outclassing world No. 17 Supanida Katethong 21-12, 21-12 in the first singles to hand India a 1-0 lead. She paved the way for 17-year-old Anmol Kharb, ranked 472 in the world, who eventually beat world no. 45 Pornpicha Choeikeewong 21-14, 21-9 in the final to secure the title win. What made this victory even more impressive was that India managed to defeat strong opponents like China, Hong Kong, and Japan en route to the title.

Sindhu emphasises that winning the gold was unexpected. "But credit goes to the entire team. It was a fantastic team effort, and I'm truly happy to have contributed to the amazing journey," she said.

Sindhu, also a five-time World Championship medallist and winner of many Super Series titles, has been struggling to regain her form after suffering an injury at the Paris Open last October. She made her comeback after a gap of four months at the Asian Team Championship, where she showed great courage, mental toughness, and skills.

Off-court, she had to look for the right team combination. After training with former All England champion Muhammad Hafiz Hashim at Suchitra Academy, she moved to Prakash Padukone Academy in Bengaluru in January this year. "I think I am at the right place at the right time. It makes a lot of difference. Prakash Sir, being a legend himself, is aware of my requirements, demands, and challenges to help me return to the big league," Sindhu said.

"With Prakash sir, I have learned to be even more patient, and positive, and keep working hard. Not that I have not done these earlier. But the intensity is something different now with him," she said.

The Badminton Asia Team Championships provided a great opportunity for players to earn valuable ranking points in the Race to Paris 2024. Moreover, the tournament also served as a qualifying event for the BWF Thomas and Uber Cup Finals 2024, with the four semifinalist teams (men and women) guaranteed a spot in the finals. Sindhu acknowledged the importance of the win while highlighting the challenges she had to endure along the way.

"Coming back from an injury layoff is never easy. I have always wanted my team to win and ensure a winning start by being the lead player. It is just fabulous the way the girls have responded in such style," the former World Champion Sindhu said. "Ending the tournament on such a high note does a world of good for all of us," she added.

"Everything takes time. But you have to believe in yourself. There is a big change in skills, technique, and other related issues as far as my game is concerned," Sindhu said. "It is a whole new team with a new coach and support staff. They know exactly what I need to be back at my best."

The Indian badminton star returned to the tour in January 2023 after taking a five-month break due to a stress fracture in her leg.

However, a difficult season marked by early exits and struggles against

top players resulted in her falling out of the Top 10. But just as she looked to be hitting her straps after the Asian Games in Hangzhou, Sindhu suffered another injury, this time to her knee, mid-match at the French Open in October. Sindhu was leading by a game in her second-round women's singles match against Thailand's Supanida Katethong when she hurt herself while trying to return a shot. Sindhu was subsequently granted a protected ranking. As per the BWF regulations, a player may request a protected ranking if they are unable to participate in tournaments for an extended period. This protection is granted when a player is unable to compete in any tournament for a minimum of three months, up to a maximum of 12 months. The player may continue to hold the protected ranking until they notify BWF that they wish to enter a tournament again.

Sindhu believes that facing tough times has strengthened her as a person, making the Asia Team Championships victory even more meaningful.

"There are a lot of emotions as this win comes after such a long break. There was the issue of what I would do. But hard work always pays off. I will gain a lot of confidence from this Asia Championship gold," Sindhu said.

"Definitely, in the Olympic year, these kinds of performances are very important. But gain, learning, and improving are everyday processes. I hope to learn a lot more," she said.

About her goals this year, Sindhu said, "There are no specific targets. I just hope that every time I go into a tournament, I give my 100 per cent. It is going to be hard, but again, you have to be at your best. It is important that you are right there mentally and physically. There is a lot of scope to improve, for sure, given the fact that the women's circuit is very challenging and competitive," she added.

"I am looking forward to a great year ahead and to ensuring that I am conscious of the kind of effort I have to put in."